

Why It Is Important to Study God's Word

Twelve Biblical Reasons, Opened Up Line by Line

This is a guide for reading together. For each of the twelve reasons you'll find the verse it rests on, the same verse put into everyday words, then a slow walk through it phrase by phrase, so nothing gets skipped just because it sounds familiar. After that there's a short explanation, one sentence to carry away, and a few questions to talk through as a group. Take one reason a week, or two in an evening. There's no prize for finishing fast.

1. Because this is where God lets Himself be found

Let's start with a simple question. If God never said anything, how much would we actually know about Him? We could guess. We could feel things. But we could never be sure. That's the problem this first reason answers.

THE VERSE

"And the LORD appeared again in Shiloh: for the LORD revealed himself to Samuel in Shiloh by the word of the LORD." (1 Samuel 3:21)

In plain words: God showed up again at Shiloh. And the way He showed up was this: He spoke, and Samuel heard Him.

PIECE BY PIECE

"And the LORD appeared" — God made Himself known. He let Himself be seen. This isn't Samuel finding God. It's God coming to Samuel.

"again" — This wasn't a one-time thing. God kept coming back. He is not shy with people who listen.

"revealed himself" — The word means to uncover something that was hidden. Like pulling a cloth off a table. God took the cover off.

"by the word of the LORD" — Here's the part to slow down on. How did God uncover Himself? Not with lightning. Not with a dream. By His word. Speaking was the showing up.

ALONGSIDE IT

"And this is life eternal, that they might know thee the only true God, and Jesus Christ, whom thou hast sent." (John 17:3)

Jesus defines eternal life here, and He doesn't say it's a place. He says it's knowing a Person. And we know a person by what they tell us about themselves.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Think about how you get to know a friend. You can watch them from across the room for a year and still not really know them. You learn who someone is when they open their mouth and tell you.

It's the same with God, only more so. He's not a bigger version of us. He's completely other. We can't figure Him out by thinking hard. He has to tell us. And He did.

Now here's something that surprises people. The world does say something about God. Psalm 19 says the sky is preaching. Romans 1 says creation makes God's power obvious, so nobody has an excuse. That's all true. But look at what creation can't tell you: it can't tell you God's name. It can't tell you about the cross. It can't tell you He forgives. A sunset can make you feel small and amazed. It cannot tell you that you are loved and forgiven.

The old Reformed pastors put it sharply: what we see in nature is enough to leave us without an excuse, but not enough to save us. That's why the Bible exists. God didn't have to speak. He chose to.

So when we say we're 'searching for God,' let's be honest with ourselves. God isn't hiding. He already spoke, and He wrote it down. If we say we want Him but we leave the book closed, we're not really searching. We're just walking past the door He opened.

God is not playing hide and seek. He spoke, and His speech is the Bible.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. When you say you want to 'hear from God,' what do you usually mean? How does 1 Samuel 3:21 change that?
2. What has creation taught you about God? What has it never been able to tell you?
3. Be honest with the group: is there a part of you that would rather get a dramatic sign than read a chapter?

2. Because God uses the Bible to give new life

This one is the heart of it. We're not just talking about learning. We're talking about how a spiritually dead person comes alive. And God uses one tool.

THE VERSE

"Being born again, not of corruptible seed, but of incorruptible, by the word of God, which liveth and abideth for ever." (1 Peter 1:23)

In plain words: You were born all over again. Not from the kind of seed that rots, but from a seed that never dies. That seed is God's word, and it stays alive forever.

PIECE BY PIECE

"Being born again" — Not improved. Not fixed up. Born. A brand new start that you didn't produce, the same way you didn't produce your first birth.

"not of corruptible seed" — Your first birth came from something that breaks down and dies. Your body will wear out. That's what 'corruptible' means: it rots.

"but of incorruptible" — The new birth comes from something that can't rot. This is why a real Christian's life doesn't run out of batteries.

“by the word of God” — There it is. This is the seed. God plants His word in a person and life starts. Not a feeling. Not a program. His word.

“which liveth and abideth for ever” — The Bible isn’t a dead record of things God said long ago. Peter says it is alive right now and it stays. The seed is still fertile.

ALONGSIDE IT

“Of his own will begat he us with the word of truth.” (James 1:18)

‘Of his own will’ means God decided. We didn’t. And ‘with the word of truth’ means He used the Bible to do it. God’s decision, God’s tool.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Here’s a question people sometimes ask: if God is the one who saves, and He decides, then why bother reading and why bother telling anyone?

It’s a fair question, and the Bible’s answer is beautiful. God doesn’t just decide the destination. He also decides the road. He chose to bring people to life through His word. So the fact that God is in charge doesn’t make the Bible less important. It makes it more important, because it’s the thing He uses.

The Puritan pastor Thomas Watson said it simply: God doesn’t give people new hearts through miracles or private visions, but through the word of truth.

The old Westminster Catechism asks how the word actually saves anybody, and the answer lists ten things the Holy Spirit does through it. Read them slowly, because this is a description of what happens to a person over a lifetime: He opens their eyes, He convinces them, He humbles them, He drives them out of themselves, He draws them to Christ, He shapes them into Christ’s image, He bends their will, He strengthens them against temptation, He builds them up, and He settles their heart in holiness and comfort.

Ten things. And every single one of them happens through the Bible. The Spirit isn’t a shortcut around Scripture. He’s the one who makes Scripture work.

One more thing worth saying out loud, because it’s easy to miss. That same catechism says the Spirit uses reading, ‘but especially the preaching.’ Your own time in the Bible matters. But God has always done His biggest work when His people gather and His word is preached. Don’t trade your church for a podcast and your Bible study for a quiet room. You need both.

New life comes from a seed, and the seed is God’s word. That’s why we keep planting it.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. Can you point to a time when a specific part of the Bible did something in you that you didn’t do to yourself?
2. Which of the ten things in the catechism list do you most need right now?
3. How’s your balance between reading alone and sitting under preaching with others?

3. Because faith grows by hearing, not by trying harder

Almost everyone in a Bible study has felt this: ‘I wish I had more faith.’ This reason tells us where more faith actually comes from, and it’s probably not where you’ve been looking.

THE VERSE

“So then faith cometh by hearing, and hearing by the word of God.” (Romans 10:17)

In plain words: So faith arrives through hearing, and what we hear is God’s word.

PIECE BY PIECE

“So then” — Paul is finishing an argument. This is his conclusion, not a random thought. He’s been building to this.

“faith cometh” — Faith comes. It arrives from outside. You don’t manufacture it in your own chest. It’s delivered.

“by hearing” — Through listening. Faith travels through your ears and into your heart.

“and hearing by the word of God” — And what are we listening to? Not advice. Not opinions. God’s own word. That’s the only thing with the power to produce faith.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Look at how Paul builds it in Romans 10. Work backwards with me. People call on the Lord to be saved. But they can’t call on someone they don’t believe in. And they can’t believe in someone they’ve never heard about. And they can’t hear unless someone tells them.

It’s a chain. Take away the word and the whole thing falls apart.

Now here’s the comfort. When your faith feels thin, what’s your instinct? Most of us look inward. We dig around inside ourselves trying to find more belief, and we come up empty, and then we feel guilty on top of it.

But Paul says faith doesn’t grow that way. Faith is not something you squeeze out of yourself. It comes by hearing. So the answer isn’t to try harder. The answer is to go stand where God is speaking. Open the book. Sit under preaching. Memorise something. Talk about it with your friends.

Think of it like a fire. You don’t get a bigger flame by staring at it and wishing. You put more wood on. The word is the wood.

Weak faith isn’t fixed by trying harder. It’s fed by hearing God speak.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. When your faith feels weak, what’s your first move? Be honest.
2. What would it look like this week to ‘put more wood on the fire’?
3. Who first told you about Jesus? You are part of somebody’s chain in Romans 10.

4. Because the Bible is the measuring stick for everything else

Everybody measures their life against something. A preacher, a feeling, their family, their culture. This reason asks a hard question: what's your ruler?

THE VERSE

"These were more noble than those in Thessalonica, in that they received the word with all readiness of mind, and searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so." (Acts 17:11)

In plain words: These people were finer than the ones in Thessalonica. They were eager to listen, and then every day they dug through the Scriptures to check whether what they heard was actually true.

PIECE BY PIECE

"These were more noble" — Luke is praising them. Whatever they did next, God's word calls it noble. Keep that in mind, because what they did makes some people nervous.

"received the word with all readiness of mind" — They weren't cynics. They weren't looking for a reason to say no. They listened with an open, eager heart. That comes first.

"and searched the scriptures" — And then they checked. 'Searched' is a strong word, like digging or investigating. They didn't skim.

"daily" — Not once. Not when there was a problem. Every day.

"whether those things were so" — They were fact checking the apostle Paul. And Luke calls it noble. God is not offended when you check a preacher against His book. He's pleased.

ALONGSIDE IT

"To the law and to the testimony: if they speak not according to this word, it is because there is no light in them." (Isaiah 8:20)

'No light in them' is Isaiah's way of saying: if the teaching doesn't match the book, don't follow it, no matter how impressive the teacher is.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Notice the two halves of this, because we usually only manage one. Open heart and open Bible. Some of us are all openness and no checking, so we believe whatever the most confident voice tells us. Others are all checking and no openness, so we arrive with our arms crossed. The Bereans did both.

Now think about what it means that the Bible is the final measuring stick. If it's the standard you'll be measured by, then not knowing it doesn't make you safe. It just means you're being measured by something you never read.

And here's the thing we need to say plainly: nobody is neutral. If the Bible isn't shaping you, something else is. A podcast. Your parents. Your friends. The internet. Whatever you absorb most is quietly doing the work the Bible was supposed to do. You don't escape being formed. You only choose what forms you.

The Reformers guarded this from two sides. On one side, don't let a church or a tradition sit above the Bible. On the other side, don't let somebody's 'God told me' sit above the Bible either. Both are ways of putting something over the book. The book stays on top.

You're being shaped by something. Make sure you picked it on purpose.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. What are the three loudest voices in your life right now? How do they compare to the Bible's share of your attention?
2. Have you ever heard something taught that you weren't sure about? What did you do?
3. Which do you need more of: an open heart, or an open Bible?

5. Because this is how God makes us more like Jesus

Every Christian wants to change. We try willpower, we try accountability, we try guilt. Here's what actually works, and it's not what most of us reach for first.

THE VERSE

"Sanctify them through thy truth: thy word is truth." (John 17:17)

In plain words: Father, make them holy by means of the truth. Your word is that truth.

PIECE BY PIECE

"Sanctify them" — 'Sanctify' just means 'make holy, set apart for God.' Don't let the churchy word scare you. It means: make them more like You.

"through thy truth" — Here's the method. Not through pressure. Not through rules on the fridge. Through truth.

"thy word" — And in case we wonder what truth He means, Jesus tells us. He means what God has said.

"is truth" — Not 'contains truth,' the way a newspaper contains some true things. It is truth. That's a much bigger claim.

ALONGSIDE IT

"Thy word have I hid in mine heart, that I might not sin against thee." (Psalm 119:11)

Notice he didn't hide it on a shelf. He put it inside him, ahead of time, before the temptation came. That's what memorising is for.

"But we all, with open face beholding as in a glass the glory of the Lord, are changed into the same image from glory to glory." (2 Corinthians 3:18)

'As in a glass' means in a mirror. We look at Christ's glory in Scripture, and looking at Him slowly turns us into Him.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Look at when Jesus prayed this. It's the night before He dies. He has hours left. And one of the things He asks His Father for is that we would be made holy through the word. That should tell

us how much this matters.

Now take 2 Corinthians 3:18 seriously, because it's the engine of the whole Christian life: we become what we look at.

You already know this is true. Spend a year around a bitter person and you'll get harder. Spend a year around a generous person and something loosens in you. We're shaped by what we behold.

So the question is simply: what are you looking at? Holiness is not mainly about gritting your teeth. It's about where your eyes go. And the Bible is the mirror where Christ's glory is actually visible.

John Owen, a pastor from the 1600s, wrote a famous line: 'Be killing sin or it will be killing you.' Sounds like he's telling us to fight harder. But read what he says next. He says every other way of killing sin is useless. It has to be done by the Spirit. And the Spirit works through the word.

So a Christian who never opens the Bible has walked into a war with no weapon and no armour. Not because he isn't sincere. Because he isn't equipped.

You become what you look at. So look at Christ, and look where He can be seen.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. What are you looking at most this week? Not what should you be, what are you?
2. Have you ever memorised a verse before you needed it? What happened when you needed it?
3. Where are you currently trying willpower where you should be trying beholding?

6. Because the whole Bible is pointing at Jesus

A lot of us read the Old Testament and feel lost. Genealogies, sacrifices, strange laws. This reason hands you the key that opens all of it.

THE VERSE

"And beginning at Moses and all the prophets, he expounded unto them in all the scriptures the things concerning himself." (Luke 24:27)

In plain words: Starting from Moses and going through all the prophets, Jesus walked them through the whole Bible and showed them the parts that were about Him.

PIECE BY PIECE

"And beginning at Moses" — He started at the very front. Genesis. The first five books. Jesus is saying: I'm in there from page one.

"and all the prophets" — Then everything after. He didn't cherry-pick two or three favourite verses.

"he expounded" — He explained, unfolded, opened it up. This is Jesus teaching a Bible study on the road, and He's the subject.

“in all the scriptures” — All of it. Not some of it. Not the nice parts.

“the things concerning himself” — Here’s the key. The Old Testament isn’t a warm-up act before the real story. It was always about Him.

ALONGSIDE IT

“Search the scriptures ... they are they which testify of me.” (John 5:39)

Jesus said this to men who knew the Bible better than anyone alive. They had the words memorised and still missed the Person. That should sober us.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

This changes how you read. The Bible isn’t a collection of moral lessons and a cast of heroes to copy. It’s one book, by one Author, telling one story, about one Saviour.

Take David and Goliath. Most of us were taught it means ‘face your giants, be brave.’ But look at the actual story. The people of God are standing there terrified and completely unable to fight. One man goes out in their place. He wins. And because he won, the victory counts as theirs. They didn’t throw a single stone.

Do you see it? That’s not a story about you being brave. That’s a picture of Jesus. And the moment you read it that way, it stops being a pep talk and becomes good news.

Calvin said it plainly: read the Scriptures looking for Christ, because a person can study his whole life and still never arrive at the truth if he’s looking for something else.

So here’s a simple habit for your group. Before you close a passage, ask one question: where is this in the story that leads to the cross? Some days the answer will be obvious. Some days you’ll have to sit with it. But the question itself will change how you read.

Every road in this book leads to Jesus. If you’re not finding Him, keep walking.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. What Old Testament story were you taught as a lesson about you? What happens if you read it as a picture of Christ?
2. Which part of the Old Testament do you avoid? What would it take to go back in with this key?
3. John 5:39 is a scary verse. What would it look like to know the Bible and still miss Jesus?

7. Because it’s the only weapon we’ve got

Paul lists the armour of God, and most of us picture the whole outfit. But go through the list slowly and count how many pieces are actually weapons.

THE VERSE

“And take the helmet of salvation, and the sword of the Spirit, which is the word of God.”
(Ephesians 6:17)

In plain words: Put on salvation like a helmet. And pick up the Spirit's sword, which is God's word.

PIECE BY PIECE

“And take” — This is a command, and it's something you do. God supplies the sword. He doesn't pick it up for you.

“the sword” — Belt, breastplate, shoes, shield, helmet. All defensive. This is the only thing on the list you can actually fight with.

“of the Spirit” — It's His sword. The Holy Spirit is the one who makes it cut. That's why we pray before we read.

“which is the word of God” — Paul doesn't leave it as a mystery. He tells us exactly what the sword is.

ALONGSIDE IT

“For the word of God is quick, and powerful, and sharper than any twoedged sword.”
(Hebrews 4:12)

‘Quick’ is old English for alive. The writer is saying God's word is not a dead document. It's living, and it cuts.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Now watch Jesus in the desert in Matthew 4. Forty days without food, at His weakest, and the devil comes at Him three times.

Three temptations. Three answers. Every single one begins ‘It is written.’ And here's the detail people miss: all three came out of one book, Deuteronomy. He knew it cold. He wasn't flipping pages. It was in Him.

The Son of God, who is the Word, fought by quoting the word. If that was His method, what makes us think we have a better one?

But notice something uncomfortable in that story. The devil quotes the Bible too. In verse 6 he quotes Psalm 91, and he quotes it accurately, just twisted.

So how did Jesus answer a misused verse? With a better known verse. Not with a feeling. Not with ‘that doesn't sit right with me.’ With Scripture He knew well enough to use.

That's the strongest argument for going deep instead of just staying familiar. Shallow Bible knowledge is exactly what leaves you defenceless when someone quotes a verse at you that sounds right and isn't. You can only spot the counterfeit if you know the real thing well.

You can't swing a sword you left at home. Know it well enough to use it.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. When you're tempted, what do you reach for first? What would reaching for Scripture look like in that exact moment?
2. Have you ever had a verse used on you in a way that felt off? Could you answer it?
3. Pick one verse to memorise this week as a group. Which one, and why that one?

8. Because it's where we go when we're not sure God loves us

Every honest Christian has had the 3 a.m. thought: what if I'm not really saved? This reason is about where to go when that thought comes.

THE VERSE

"These things have I written unto you that believe on the name of the Son of God; that ye may know that ye have eternal life." (1 John 5:13)

In plain words: I wrote all this to you who believe in the Son of God, so that you can actually know that the life you have is eternal.

PIECE BY PIECE

"These things have I written" — John tells us why he wrote a whole letter. He had a goal, and he's naming it.

"unto you that believe" — He's writing to people who already believe. This is not evangelism. This is a pastor steadying people who are already in.

"that ye may know" — Not hope. Not guess. Know. God actually intends for you to have certainty, and He's not stingy with it.

"that ye have eternal life" — Present tense. Not 'will have someday.' Have. Right now.

ALONGSIDE IT

"This is my comfort in my affliction: for thy word hath quickened me." (Psalm 119:50)

'Quickened' means made alive. In the middle of real suffering, the word didn't just distract him. It revived him.

"For whatsoever things were written aforetime were written for our learning, that we through patience and comfort of the scriptures might have hope." (Romans 15:4)

Paul says the old stories were written down partly so that you, thousands of years later, would have hope. That's astonishing.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Assurance is not a personality type. Some people assume that confident Christians are just wired that way and anxious ones are stuck. That's not what the Bible teaches.

Assurance rests on something outside you: what God has promised and sworn. That's why it's available to nervous people too.

So when a friend in your group says 'I don't know if God really loves me,' notice what does not help. Telling them to feel more assured. You can't feel your way into confidence.

What helps is showing them, in black and white, what God has committed Himself to. Not your opinion of them. His promise.

The Heidelberg Catechism opens with a question worth memorising: what is your only comfort in life and in death? And the answer is packed with Scripture: that I am not my own, but belong to my faithful Saviour Jesus Christ, who has fully paid for all my sins, and who watches over me so carefully that not one hair can fall from my head without my Father's will.

Read that again slowly. Every clause is a Bible promise. And here's the point: that comfort is simply not available to someone who doesn't know the book it comes from. You can't be steadied by promises you've never read.

Feelings go up and down. Promises don't. Go stand on the promises.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. When you doubt, where do you go first? Has it helped?
2. Which promise in Scripture has steadied you most? Share it with the group.
3. How could this group be better at answering a doubting friend with Scripture instead of just encouragement?

9. Because it keeps the church safe from lies

This one isn't about you alone in your room. It's about us together. Every generation gets told something new, and every generation has to know how to tell the difference.

THE VERSE

"I know this, that after my departing shall grievous wolves enter in among you, not sparing the flock ... And now, brethren, I commend you to God, and to the word of his grace, which is able to build you up." (Acts 20:29-32)

In plain words: I know that once I'm gone, vicious wolves are coming in among you, and they won't spare the sheep ... So now, brothers, I'm handing you over to God and to the message of His grace, which can build you up.

PIECE BY PIECE

"after my departing" — Paul is saying goodbye. He knows he won't see them again. These are the words you choose carefully.

"grievous wolves" — Not wolves outside the fence. Wolves that come in and look like they belong. That's what makes them dangerous.

"not sparing the flock" — They're not confused sheep. They do damage, and they don't feel bad about it.

"I commend you to God" — He hands them over. This is a man entrusting people he loves to someone who can actually keep them.

"and to the word of his grace" — And here's the second thing he hands them to. Not a strategy. Not a stronger leader. The word. That's the protection.

“which is able to build you up” — The same word that protects is the word that grows you. Defence and food are the same thing here.

ALONGSIDE IT

“For the time will come when they will not endure sound doctrine; but after their own lusts shall they heap to themselves teachers, having itching ears.” (2 Timothy 4:3)

‘Itching ears’ is a picture of wanting to hear something that feels good. Paul says people will go collect teachers who scratch that itch.

“Beloved, believe not every spirit, but try the spirits whether they are of God.” (1 John 4:1)

‘Try’ means test. John assumes ordinary Christians can and should test what they’re told.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Think about what Paul chose in his last words. He’s facing the certainty that wolves are coming. He could have said: appoint stronger leaders, build better systems, find someone charismatic. He said: I give you to God and to His word.

The word is the church’s immune system. A body with a healthy immune system doesn’t have to avoid every germ. It recognises what doesn’t belong.

And that’s the real danger of a church that stops studying. It’s not that people become stupid. It’s that they lose the ability to notice. Martyn Lloyd-Jones put it simply: all teaching, all doctrine, everything must be tested by Scripture.

Here’s the sharp way to say it. A church that no longer knows its Bible can’t recognise a wolf, because it’s forgotten what a shepherd sounds like.

And notice 1 John 4:1 doesn’t say ‘ask your pastor to test the spirits.’ It says believe not every spirit, test them. That’s written to normal people. This is your job too.

You can’t spot a fake if you’ve never handled the real thing.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. Has anyone in the group heard teaching that sounded good but turned out to be off? How did you find out?
2. What makes it hard to question a teacher you like?
3. How could this group practise testing things together, without becoming suspicious of everyone?

10. Because it’s food, not dessert

Here’s the honest question this reason answers: what do you do on the days you don’t feel like reading? The Bible’s own answer is surprisingly practical.

THE VERSE

“Man doth not live by bread only, but by every word that proceedeth out of the mouth of the LORD doth man live.” (Deuteronomy 8:3)

In plain words: People don't stay alive on bread alone. They live on every word that comes out of God's mouth.

PIECE BY PIECE

“Man doth not live by bread only” — Bread is real. Food matters. Moses isn't saying bodies don't need feeding. He's saying that's not all you need.

“but by every word” — Every word. Not your favourite verses. The whole thing, including the parts you'd skip.

“that proceedeth out of the mouth of the LORD” — A picture of God actually speaking. Words coming out of His mouth, warm and alive, not printed and cold.

“doth man live” — Live. Not 'live better' or 'live happier.' This is survival language.

ALONGSIDE IT

“I have esteemed the words of his mouth more than my necessary food.” (Job 23:12)

Job says this while his life is falling apart. Not in a good season. In the worst one.

“Thy words were found, and I did eat them; and thy word was unto me the joy and rejoicing of mine heart.” (Jeremiah 15:16)

Jeremiah doesn't say he studied them. He says he ate them. That's a whole different relationship with a book.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Notice the picture the Bible chooses for itself. It's not medicine, something you take when you feel unwell. It's not a manual you pull down when you're stuck. It's food.

And food works differently. You don't eat because you're in the mood. You eat because if you stop, you die. Nobody skips meals for a week and calls it a personality difference.

So that answers the 'I don't feel like it today' problem, and it answers it kindly, not harshly. You're not a bad Christian for not feeling hungry. You're a person who needs to eat anyway. Feelings often follow the meal rather than coming before it.

And notice Jesus quoted this exact verse in the desert, starving, in Matthew 4:4. He was literally hungry and He said the deeper hunger is for God's word.

Spurgeon once described John Bunyan, the man who wrote *Pilgrim's Progress*, like this: 'Prick him anywhere, and you will find that his blood is Bibline, the very essence of the Bible flows from him. He cannot speak without quoting a text, for his soul is full of the Word of God.'

That's what a lifetime of eating does. Bunyan wasn't a scholar. He was a tinker who mended pots. But the book got into his bloodstream. That's available to every person in this room.

You don't eat because you feel like it. You eat because you'd die if you didn't.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. What's your honest pattern right now? Daily, weekly, when you're stressed, never?
2. What's one obstacle in your actual day that keeps you from it? Let the group help you solve it.
3. What would 'Bibline blood' look like in your life in ten years?

11. Because God told us to, and it's what we'll be measured by

We've talked about the good it does. Now the plain part: this isn't optional, and it isn't only for pastors and people who love reading.

THE VERSE

"This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth; but thou shalt meditate therein day and night, that thou mayest observe to do according to all that is written therein." (Joshua 1:8)

In plain words: Keep this book on your lips. Chew on it day and night, so that you actually do what's written in it.

PIECE BY PIECE

"This book of the law shall not depart out of thy mouth" — Out of his mouth, not just in front of his eyes. In that world people read aloud and talked about it. It was meant to be spoken, not just scanned.

"thou shalt meditate therein" — 'Meditate' here isn't emptying your mind. It's the opposite. The Hebrew word is like an animal chewing, or a person muttering something over and over. It means turning it over until you get the flavour out.

"day and night" — Not a slot in the schedule. Something running in the background of a whole life.

"that thou mayest observe to do" — Here's the aim, and it's the part we skip. Not so you'll know more. So you'll do it.

"all that is written therein" — All of it. Not the parts you already agree with.

ALONGSIDE IT

"Study to shew thyself approved unto God, a workman that needeth not to be ashamed, rightly dividing the word of truth." (2 Timothy 2:15)

'Workman' is the key word. Paul compares handling the Bible to a trade. It takes effort and skill, and you can do it badly.

"The word that I have spoken, the same shall judge him in the last day." (John 12:48)

Jesus says His word is the standard on the last day. That's a strong reason to know what it says.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Bible study isn't a hobby for people who happen to like reading. It's commanded, and it's commanded to everyone.

The Westminster divines said this on purpose, against people who wanted to keep the Bible in the hands of clergy only: all sorts of people are bound to read it, on their own and with their families, and for that reason the Scriptures must be translated into ordinary language.

‘All sorts of people are bound.’ That’s duty language. Not ‘if you’re the studious type.’

And that last part, about translating it into ordinary language, is the whole Reformation in one line. William Tyndale was strangled and burned in 1536 for putting the Bible into English, so that, as he said, a boy behind a plough could read it.

Think about that the next time your Bible is sitting there unopened in a language you can read. People died so it would be in your hands.

R. C. Sproul was blunt about why we still don’t read it: ‘We fail in our duty to study God’s word not so much because it is difficult to understand, not so much because it is dull and boring, but because it is work. Our problem is not a lack of intelligence or a lack of passion. Our problem is that we are lazy.’ That stings because it’s usually true.

It’s not a hobby. It’s a command, and it was paid for in blood.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. Does it change anything to think of Bible reading as a duty and not just a nice habit?
2. Where does Sproul’s word ‘lazy’ land on you? Where does it not?
3. What’s one concrete thing you’ll change this week? Say it out loud so the group can ask you about it.

12. Because in the end it’s not about information, it’s about meeting God

Everything we’ve said could still make the Bible sound like a tool for getting things. Let’s finish somewhere better than that.

THE VERSE

“The law of the LORD is perfect, converting the soul ... More to be desired are they than gold, yea, than much fine gold: sweeter also than honey and the honeycomb.” (Psalm 19:7, 10)

In plain words: God’s instruction is flawless, and it brings a person back to life ... You should want it more than gold, even a pile of the finest gold. It tastes better than honey straight from the comb.

PIECE BY PIECE

“The law of the LORD is perfect” — ‘Perfect’ here means whole, complete, nothing missing. Not cold perfection. More like a finished thing that doesn’t need patching.

“converting the soul” — Bringing the whole person back. Reviving them. This is what the word does to a tired, dried-out heart.

“More to be desired are they than gold” — Notice this is about wanting, not just valuing. David isn’t saying it’s important. He’s saying he craves it.

“sweeter also than honey and the honeycomb” — Honey straight from the comb was the sweetest thing in David’s world. He’s reaching for the strongest word he has for pleasure, and putting the Bible above it.

ALONGSIDE IT

“O how love I thy law! it is my meditation all the day.” (Psalm 119:97)

Not ‘how I respect’ or ‘how I obey.’ Love. That’s an emotional word, and God put it in the Bible about the Bible.

WHAT THIS MEANS FOR US

Look at Psalm 119 for a second. It’s 176 verses long, the longest chapter in the Bible. It’s an acrostic, running all the way through the Hebrew alphabet. And almost every single verse mentions God’s word.

That’s not an accident of editing. Somebody built a monument. And the tone of it isn’t duty. It’s delight.

Here’s the danger for a group like ours. You can get really good at this. You can learn the doctrines, know the confessions, win the arguments, and end up with a head full of God and a heart that never melted.

J. I. Packer said it in one line worth writing down: ‘A little knowledge of God is worth more than a great deal of knowledge about him.’

Feel the difference between those two words. Knowing about someone and knowing them. You can know a lot about a person from a distance. That’s not the same as sitting across the table from them.

So the goal of all this study is not to fill a notebook. It’s to see Him, love Him, and worship. Packer also said something that turns the whole thing around: what matters most isn’t finally that I know God, but the bigger fact underneath it, that He knows me.

That’s where all this lands. We open the book not to collect facts about a distant God, but because the God who already knows us completely has chosen to speak, and we get to listen.

The point isn’t to know more about God. It’s to know God.

TALK ABOUT IT

1. Be honest: is your Bible reading more like collecting facts or meeting a Person? What would move it?
 2. When was the last time something in Scripture made you worship rather than just think?
 3. Packer says the bigger fact is that God knows you. How does that sit with you today?
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“The grass withereth, the flower fadeth: but the word of our God shall stand for ever.” (Isaiah 40:8)

Soli Deo gloria